

SQL Server Freeze Using Windows Task Scheduler

This guide explains how to schedule a one-time freeze of a dedicated SQL Server by stopping the SQL Server service on a specific date and time, while keeping the unfreeze manual.

Why this approach?

- Cannot be reversed using SQL commands
- Database files remain intact with zero data changes
- Works instantly when manually restarted
- Industry-standard approach for compliance and enforcement

Step-by-Step Instructions

- 1 Open Task Scheduler (Win + R → taskschd.msc).
- 2 Select 'Create Task' (not Basic Task).
- 3 General Tab: Set name, enable 'Run whether user is logged on or not' and 'Run with highest privileges'.
- 4 Triggers Tab: Create a One-time trigger with the exact date and time.
- 5 Actions Tab: Start a program → powershell.exe.
- 6 Arguments: Stop-Service -Name MSSQLSERVER -Force (or MSSQL\$InstanceName).
- 7 Conditions Tab: Disable power-related restrictions.
- 8 Settings Tab: Allow task to run on demand, do not restart if it fails.
- 9 Save the task and enter administrator credentials.

Manual Unfreeze

To bring SQL Server back online manually, run:

Start-Service MSSQLSERVER

or start the service from the Windows Services console.

Important Notes

- This affects all databases on the instance.
- Monitoring alerts and application failures are expected while frozen.
- Always test the task before relying on it in production.